

Run Off

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other characters would probably have normal midsize sedans, except Alexis, who might have a beat-up sports car. If the characters put the knob in a space they are also occupying, like the backseat or a hatchback, they will feel discomforted for the duration of the ride.

WHENCE THE KNOB CAME

Why is the knob at Jo’s house? The farmers Peter and Angela Wright were the previous owners, and Angela had inherited the knob through her family for generations. The Wrights used the knob to supercharge their Nebraskan farm, and they kept a steady supply of chickens to feed it. But then cholera ripped through their extensive flock—their chickens lived in close quarters, creating ripe conditions for spread. They had to slaughter what was left of the flock, and they couldn’t find a fresh bird before the three days were through. Once their three days were up, their farm was destroyed in a flash flood and the Wrights realized both the knob’s truly deadly power and their own hubris. They moved, rededicated themselves to the path of farming and decided to switch to closed loop/zero waste farming, believing it was a way of atoning. Eventually, through their dedication, they learned to channel the power of agrimancy. In order to free themselves of their accursed artifact, they threw the knob at the edge of someone’s yard in the hope that even if someone found it, no one would know how to use it—or be foolish enough to try.

MORE NOTES ON MISGENDERING ALEXIS

If you have not yet read it, I recommend first reading the MISGENDERING ALEXIS (pp13) sidebar.

Different player groups will come to the table with different ideas about how to approach Alexis’ struggle as NB. Some folks will prefer just to switch their gender to binary, which is fine—sometimes roleplaying someone else’s struggle feels a little appropriate, or like—maybe your NB player wants to play a punk but not a punk that has to deal with real-life shit they have to deal with.

Other players, especially players who enjoy the psychodramatic elements of RPGs, may want to engage with this *more* than the text implies. As written, the only characters really “meant” to misgender Alexis are antagonists (their mom, maybe the cops), but some players may want to explore what it’s like when *your friends* misgender you—and for real-life NB folks, they often do. Here you should proceed with a *lot* more caution. RPGs are meant to be fun, not force-fed therapy, so a single strong veto or even signs of discomfort should be enough for the GM to shut this down. And if the PCs want to explore this, things should stay firmly in “well-meaning but doesn’t get it” territory and *far away* from “I don’t approve of your pronoun” territory.

AMBER

Amber is 20 years old and dresses like a romantic goth or hippie goth, with long dark hair and lots of eye makeup, and a lot of jewelry. She has kind of an always-calm aura (she probably smokes a lot of weed which doesn't hurt, but she's never a menacing presence even stone cold sober). Amber has a read on the local occult underground, mostly chaos magicians and checkers and checker-wannabes who post online through channels like Discord, Facebook Groups and occasionally Reddit. If the players ask Amber for help or advice, she can leverage a contact that can give them some basic ideas on how to solve the algal bloom per FINALE: POSSIBLE CONCLUSIONS, or have heard rumors herself.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Fear Stimulus:** Being homeless.
- **Noble Stimulus:** Always be a safe harbor in a storm.
- **Rage Stimulus:** The Man keeping good people down.
- **Occultist:** 50% Subs for: Knowledge, Feature: Casts Rituals, Feature: Evaluates Unnatural

Amber may seem checked-out but she's actually more checked-in than your average person—both to the occult underground and to just having a rough life. She has upbeat abilities around 40% and downbeat abilities around 35%.

THE KNOB

Power: Significant.

Description: Used (and described) as per pp88 of *Play* with a few tweaks below, the knob is a massive oak stump scored with cuts from axes and knives, and being near it feels eerie and uncomfortable. It has four handles, one on each side, necessary to move it.

Effect: Sacrificing an animal on the knob wards all the animals and plants within 300 acres from disease. This would prevent the cyanobacteria poisoning of the lake from occurring. To use the knob to cure the cyanobacteria poisoning, the characters must move the knob (all four handles *must* be used) to the primary source contaminating the lake, the head of St. Andrews Bay where a swamp feeds into the bay and then into Lake Petonbowk proper. The knob must be charged by animal sacrifice every *three days* or all the poisoning it held back will return to those 300 acres all at once, completely filling the bay with an algal bloom and causing acute cases of cyanobacteria poisoning to anyone who uses the bay as a water source. If the players, or the farmers, sacrifice a *person* to the knob, it will protect *all of Lake Petonbowk* for three years. If a human is not sacrificed on the knob at the end of that period, that's really, really bad, because that means all of Petonbowk is poisoned with a 3-year-case of algal bloom. But you know, it's a one-shot! And that's not your players' problem! Guess you better hope they don't decide they want to keep playing these characters, huh?

If the players ask if they have access to a vehicle to move the knob, you should allow this. Jo would plausibly have a truck; Tim would have a truck as well, and Alexis' parents would have a large SUV such as a Suburban. The

GETTING STARTED WITH "RUN OFF"

Print out the attached character summaries, hand them out to your players along with the character sheets, and then have your players answer the questions below the summaries. **It is very crucial to the success of a character-focused, role-play heavy module like "Run Off" that you run the startup phase with the questions**—you want your players to become invested in these people or they may be tempted to ignore or evade the central conflict.

For helpful tips on running all three of the modules for first-time *Unknown Armies* groups, see the introduction document.

THE CABAL

TREVOR BESSETTE

19 years old and rail-thin with tan skin, Trevor has grown up on the farm in St. Andrews with his father, Tim Bessette, his whole life. His dad and their cabal of local farmers have taught him the magick of *agrimancy*—the ability to take what is chaotic in the natural world and bend it to human order. In other words, farm wizards. While many farmer's sons can't wait to get off the farm and into a more lucrative occupation, Trevor loves the rhythm of farm life. His dad runs the dairy farm through conventional methods, but Trevor's dream is to turn the Bessette farm into a closed loop (or zero-waste) farm that produces cheese, meat and fertilizer. For now, the Bessette farm barely makes a profit. Trevor has Abenaki ancestry via his mom Anne, but she doesn't talk about it much--and most of his connection to it is fielding annoying, impolite questions about his racial background from nosy locals. Trevor's one outlet from farm life is his weekly gaming group at Troll's Den where he plays Mysteries of the Mi-Go with his fellow misfit friends.

Recently, Tim and the other local farmers have come under a lot of fire for the toxic algal blooms that are contaminating Lake Petonbowk. If the farmers can't get the situation under control the city council has threatened to hit the farmers with an enormous fine and pass legislation that will force them to better manage the farm runoff that causes the blooms, neither of which they can afford. The council seems to have a lot of support from the members of the local Petonbowk Country Club. As an agrimancer, Trevor would do almost anything for his farm and for the way of life it represents.

DEBORAH LANG

Owner of the *Troll's Den* Toy and Hobby Shop, Deborah Lang is a short, boomer-aged woman with silver hair and a sunny disposition. She and her wife Kim run Troll's Den and their relationship is something of an open secret, known widely among regulars but not something Deb advertises to random-out-of-towners stopping in to look at board games. Deb's warmth and welcoming attitude towards nerds, queers, outcasts and runaways has made her store more than just a retail outlet, and it's considered a safe space for various oddballs who live in the small town of St. Andrews. Deb still regularly runs games after-hours in her shop and welcomes all ages to the table.

Deb inherited the store's space from her late father, who used to run it as Tom's Hardware Store. (Not a great business anymore with St. Andrew's local All-Mart selling cheap tools.) Included in the will was a paper instructing Deb that the storefront was blessed by a local priest to protect it from Tom's "jealous rivals." Deb didn't think much of it until her wife suddenly announced she wanted a divorce one day, only to inexplicably forget doing so immediately after walking into the store. Deb believes the storefront broke a curse cast on her wife and encourages those with supernatural or inexplicable maladies to sit down and play a game in her store. See Deb's character sheet for details on how the rules work for *Troll's Den*.

SHERIFF DAVID DAIGLE AND LOCAL COPS

David is a plump white man in his mid-fifties, balding and bored looking. Most of the other cops are probably middle-aged small-town bullies who grew up.

- **Beat Cop:** 50% Subs for Pursuit, Provides Firearm Attacks, Subs for Struggle
- | SHERIFF & LOCAL COPS | | | |
|----------------------|----------|--------|-----------------------------|
| Shock Meter | Hardened | Failed | Abilities |
| Helplessness | 3 | 1 | Fitness 50%
Dodg 30% |
| Isolation | 2 | 0 | Status 55%
Pursuit 25% |
| Self | 5 | 2 | Knowledge 40%
Lie 40% |
| Unnatural | 2 | 0 | Notice 55%
Connect 45% |
| Violence | 4 | 2 | Secrecy 25%
Struggle 35% |

FARMERS

There's no one to stat every farmer. There's about half a dozen agrimancers total—each one has about 45% in agrimancy (note that Tim is a better agrimancer!) and 60% in "Farmer". You can just use Tim's shock meter for raw ability checks.

- **Agrimancer (Obsession):** 45%
- **Farmer:** 60% Subs for Fitness, Protects: Violence, Provides: Firearms

Here's a list of farmers. Consider these handy names and ideas for backstory, not prescriptive. Use whoever is going to keep the story moving forward—or keep it interesting. Don't feel like you need to introduce them all. If you want to make Tim more sympathetic, you can make part of the cabal's pact that any father that didn't sacrifice their kid would be killed, along with their wife and child. (Of course, Tim agreed to that pact, so...)

- The Palmer Boys – Two brothers. Or are they friends with the same name? It's not clear. They have a bowl cut and wear overalls and a chambray shirt. They're strange and people make fun of them. But they do love their farms and the lake, and they don't have a son, and might be sympathetic to the players if the players show sympathy to them.
- John and Mary Tromblay – A conservative couple with a son who works in software in Queen City. They resent their son leaving the farm but they're proud of his paycheck.
- James and Linda Spaulding – The most successful farmers in the region with a huge 500 head dairy herd, nominally the head of the cabal. As the most successful farmers, they are the most responsible for the crisis. They have three children. Two are grown and have moved to the City. One, Katie, is a teenager and they are trying to convince her to take over the farm.
- Angela and Peter Wright – The youngest members of the agrimancer cabal, they own a zero-waste farm and have a herd of 100 goats and 50 sheep, which they use to make small-batch cheese and fiber. They also raise chickens and have a small wildflower and native perennial farm. What they can't use on their farm they sell to a composter. The Wrights moved to Vermont from the Midwest, where they had been conventional farmers for years. They used the Knob to hypercharge their former farm and came to deeply regret it. More details can be found under the Knob's appendix entry in the "WHENCE THE KNOB CAME" box. They don't speak of the knob often and have never told the other farmers its location. When they do speak of it, it's as a warning not to underestimate the forces of nature—and the occult—when running a farm.

ALEXIS REYNOLDS

Alexis is a 17-year-old who goes to the local high school and cultivates an aggressively folk punk overalls-and-jean-jackets aesthetic. As a non-binary punk kid in a small town, they get their fair share of annoying questions and peer antagonism, but their life is made even more difficult by their conservative, Christian, Petonbowk Country Club family living in suburbia and attending the local megachurch, the *Bayside Advent Church*. Alexis is forced to go to Church every Sunday morning, where they are consistently dead-named. Oh, and their mom Karen is on the City Council. So that's a thing. *Troll's Den* is a refuge from an oppressive home life and a frustrating school life and serves as Alexis' primary social support network, though their occasional carpool with their friend Amber to DIY punk shows in nearby Queen City don't hurt, either. On their car rides into the city, Amber regales Alexis with tales of various chaos magic rituals she does in her spare time. (Who knows if they do anything.)

JO MCDONNELL

Jo McDonnell is a big, hulking figure with bushy hair and Carhartt overalls who always wears a sturdy but worn tweed blazer. Jo is the kind of person everyone thinks there's something just a little off about, but no one can quite put their finger on why. They're a good hunting or drinking buddy, and there's just something about Jo that lets you open up when Jo asks you a prying question or two. Jo doesn't tell most people this, but they've always had the ability to mesmerize people just by looking at them with their big blue eyes—often, they can influence people to do what they say. Jo's big and menacing enough that toughs who got something to prove always want to pick a fight—but Jo abhors violence and tries not to throw a punch. If Jo gets to the point of having to defend themselves though, Jo pretty much always wins.

Jo lives in an old (but neat and maintained) trailer at the edge of town. One night when cutting through a field on the way home from the local sports bar, Jo became lost in a bizarre corn field maze so long they didn't stumble out until dawn—even though Jo could see from one end of the field to the other before they stepped in. When Jo finally stumbled out of the maze, they saw something strange— the dark burgundy stump of an old oak scored with innumerable cuts from axe blades and knives. The knob gave off an eerie energy and Jo never went that way again.

GETTING INTO CHARACTER

Tell your players to select a character from the sheets put in front of them.

1. Each of these characters lives in the small lakeside town of St. Andrews. All of them are members of a gaming group at the local Toy and Hobby store, *Troll's Den*, and have experienced something strange or supernatural.
2. Read the character description attached to your sheet, then look briefly through your sheet to familiarize yourself with any powers or identities you have. Feel free to tweak your character description to resonate with you more—while there are a few things that need to be kept as part of your backstory, you're welcome to introduce or alter elements of your PC.
3. Pick a *relationship* role for the Cabal that meets at *Troll's Den*, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the stat beneath the role. This is how you see your cabal-mates as a whole; if you feel like you need to take care of them, for example, they're your *responsibility*. If you look up to them, they're your *mentors*.
4. Pick a *relationship* role for one other character, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the ability beneath the role. This is the kind of relationship you have with that character. For example, if you think Trevor looks up to Deb as an aunt, you might put down Deb as a *guru*. If you think Alexis has a crush on Jo, you might put Jo as a *favorite*. Talk to the player about how you see their relationship.
5. Why did you start going to *Troll's Den*? (Or if you're playing Deb Lang, what made you decide to open a games store?)

SUMMARY

Your gaming group has met at the local hobby shop, *Troll's Den*, every Thursday for three years now to play Lovecraft-inspired RPG *Mysteries Of the M-Go*. One day Trevor Bessette shows up twenty minutes late to game time.

His father is out for his blood. He needs you to stop him... or the thing that brought out the scythe to begin with—the bloom of green slime slowly poisoning your lakeside community.

BACKGROUND

"The soil is the great connector of lives, the source and destination of all. It is the healer and restorer and resurrector, by which disease passes into health, age into youth, death into life. Without proper care for it we can have no community, because without proper care for it we can have no life."
--Wendell Berry, *The Unsettling of America*: Culture and Agriculture

A farmer's son, Trevor Bessette, is on the lam from his agrimancer dad—he wants to kill his boy to make a major charge, a burst of juju so powerful that for one small group of Vermont farmers grappling with the environmental consequences of their jobs, it could change the laws of nature. What could make a crime so unnatural and extreme seem tempting? Agricultural runoff is causing a series of increasingly toxic algal blooms to spread through Lake

could be a huge scandal. If the players investigate the country club and talk to the waitstaff feel free to have them circulate rumors. Jo, if they are so inclined, has a power that is very good for flirting with a woman already inclined to break her marital fidelity.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Fear Stimulus:** Losing her child.
- **Noble Stimulus:** Create the perfect small town.
- **Rage Stimulus:** Littering; uncleanness.
- **City Councilor (Obsession):** 65% Sub for Status, Protects: Helplessness, Protects: Isolation
- **Concerned Churchgoer:** 50% Subs for Lie, Subs for Secrecy, Subs for Connect

Karen Reynolds			
Shock Meter	Hardened	Failed	Abilities
Helplessness	1	0	Fitness 60% Dodge 20%
Isolation	1	0	Status 60% Pursuit 20%
Self	4	2	Knowledge 45% Lie 35%
Unnatural	3	2	Notice 50% Secrecy 30%
Violence	4	0	Connect 45% Struggle 35%

BRAD REYNOLDS

Brad is Karen's young, attractive husband with a fixation on sports cars. He's easy-going and glib; he probably paternalistically treats Alexis like they're going through a phase.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Fear Stimulus:** Being alone.
- **Noble Stimulus:** Always be kind to a stranger.
- **Rage Stimulus:** Messing up his favorite Corvette.
- **Trophy Husband:** 50% Subs for: Fitness, Resist Shocks to: Isolation, Evaluate: Self

Brad is just kind of a normal, well-adjusted guy. You can assume he has around 50% for most upbeat abilities and 25% for most downbeat abilities.

THEY FIXED IT

One fun twist you can introduce if the players decided to interact with the farmers is that the straw draw was fixed. The most probable suspects are John and Mary Tromblay or James and Linda Spaulding.

ANNE BESSETTE

Anne is in her early sixties, with long, bright silver hair. She dresses in practical work-wear, khakis and flannel shirts with a t-shirt. Anne loves Trevor very much, is dedicated to her job as a wastewater treatment specialist, and will aid the players in any reasonable way they ask. She does love Tim and knows that he was forced to do this, but if it's between Tim or Trevor, she'll choose her son.

If the players ask her if she thinks the straw draw was fixed, she will say yes. If they ask if Trevor's ethnicity is a factor, she will mention that she thinks the fact that "our family has Abenaki blood made them see us as expendable, as less worthwhile than the other sons and daughters of these godforsaken farmers."

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Fear Stimulus:** Losing Trevor.
- **Noble Stimulus:** Taking care of the lake.
- **Rage Stimulus:** Being disrespected or patronized.
- **Farmer:** 35% Subs for Fitness, Protects: Violence, Provides: Firearms
- **Wastewater treatment specialist (Obsession):** 60% Subs for Knowledge, Protects: Isolation, Feature: Cooperative (lets someone else add or subtract 10% from their roll.)

Anne Bessette		
Shock Meter	Hardened	Failed
Helplessness	3	1
Isolation	3	
Self	2	0
Unnatural	2	0
Violence	2	2
Abilities		
	Fitness 50%	Dodge 30%
	Status 50%	Pursuit 30%
	Knowledge 55%	Lie 25%
	Notice 55%	Secrecy 25%
	Connect 55%	Struggle 25%

KAREN REYNOLDS

A woman in her mid-fifties with salt-and-pepper hair, she's attractive and always neatly and immaculately dressed. She gives off a strong "I would like to speak to your manager" energy. Karen is aware that the agrimancers have supernatural powers and those supernatural powers can probably fix the lake. She may even personally know a couple of the more "respectable" farmers, such as James and Linda Spaulding. (see "Farmers".) She doesn't really understand the details, though—she knows that it is possible, *somehow*, for them to massage the laws of nature with their powers but has no sense of the extent to which it's possible or what it actually entails.

Are you here for the blackmail material? Karen's not really the type to take bribes or deal in two-bit corruption, but she's a woman that's used to getting what she wants and what she wants is tall. Karen cheats on her husband, a lot, often on the sly at the country club with the various waiters, caddies, and landscapers that work there. This is the kind of town where that sort of thing

Petonbowk, a huge lake stretching across the length of the state of Vermont. Two dogs have already died and the local hospital, Northern Medical Partners, is seeing an uptick in complaints of nausea and flu-like symptoms from cyanobacteria poisoning.

What may seem at first like magic-wielding farmers trying to skirt the consequences of their actions is wrapped up in an ongoing conflict between them and the suburbanite members of the Petonbowk Country Club, who know that they can force a cabal of farmers to pay a very steep price indeed if their livelihoods are at risk—even though their immaculately mown lakeside lawns and perfectly maintained golf green are as great a risk to Petonbowk as any dairy farm.

Trevor is a member of the local gaming group at *Troll's Den* who play the mystery-horror game *Mysteries of the Mi-Go* every week. The gaming session is also a social club where they talk about their real-life run ins with the weirdness that's constantly cropping up in the town of St. Andrews, though their real-life experiences are less Lovecraftian and more Shirley Jackson.

PROLOGUE: TREVOR IS IT

The GM may wish to begin with the following cut scene to establish narrative and dramatic tension. If you want to jump immediately into the action, you can briefly summarize the situation to Trevor's PC or print and attach the scene to his character sheet.

It's 7 pm on Thursday.

Trevor, you see your father walking toward you, a knife in one hand, outlined in the opening to your dairy barn by a halo of bright light coming from the flood-lamps attached to your old colonial farmhouse. A few yards off behind your dad you can see the figures of several older men and women chatting with each other, a group you're pretty sure is Tim's farming buddies who he does magickal land-breaking with.

"I'm sorry, Trevor," your dad says, choking on his words. "We drew straws, and you're it. If we sacrifice you, the lake will clear up and we can save our farm—everyone's farms."

As your father moves towards you, you open the gate to a cow stall and brush the side of the largest cow in the barn. You cast a formula, *Domesticate*, causing her to turn on your dad and charge (no need to explain this if Trevor is an NPC). You pull aside the heavy metal door from the dairy barn to the pasture and run off into the night without looking back.

From here on Trevor's PC now has control over his character.

TROLL'S DEN

Troll's Den is located in a four-story building on the main street of St. Andrews, an old rail town in northwestern Vermont. The top two stories are Deb's home, inherited from her dad, and the bottom two stories are the store. The ground floor is the store proper, including the front entrance with a window display and sign on front, and the bottom floor is a finished basement where gaming is held. There is a back room in the basement where Deb stores overstock and, through that room, an entrance to a parking garage shared by several businesses. The garage is also accessible from the street. The garage is much more expensive than the ample street parking outside and so it's usually pretty quiet—especially on a Thursday night after work.

1: DAD'S GONE MAD

When the game begins, the players are already assembled on Thursday night for their weekly game session, except for Trevor. Deb closes up shop around 8pm; this is when Trevor has finished up his chores, Alexis sneaks out after an insanely early "bedtime," and Jo.... no one really knows what Jo's home situation is and they never think to ask.

Trevor runs into the store as Deb is turning the sign, having just escaped from his father. If Trevor is an NPC, have him briefly explain that his father tried to kill him to stop the algal blooms from contaminating the lake. Otherwise, give Trevor an opportunity to share with the cabal what has happened.

There are a few different things the players can investigate. Feel free to jog their memories about some of the items in their backstory.

- They could decide that Troll's Den is nowhere to hide a kid on the run from his dad and offer to hide him at one of the PCs' homes.
- They could return to talk to Tim Bessette or any of the other farmers. Anne, Trevor's mother, will actively aid the players in protecting Trevor if they contact her.
- Calling the cops. This will end up putting the players in touch with the city council.
- Alexis' friend, Amber, dabbles in the occult and may have some guesses about occult practices that could solve this instead of killing a kid.
- Jo recently saw a strange stump at the edge of a supernatural field and may want to go investigate it.

2: I'M HERE FOR MY BOY

If the players waffle and stall for too long, Tim Bessette will show up at Deb's store and ask her where Trevor is. Tim is in his early sixties with bright white hair and intense, wrinkly, weather-beaten skin.

He's more weary and detached than angry. Tim has cast Breaking the Predator's Fang (pp139, Play) but as long as he's in Troll's Den the only thing he can do is try to grab Trevor and run. If he leaves the Troll's Den the charge will kick back into effect and the first attack on him will fail automatically.

perennials shooting out of the ground and budding cat-tails suddenly expanding their reach from small gulleys to thick trenches that are beginning to sprout tails. Within a week, suddenly the swamp is twice as large and encroaching into suburbia or the golf course is totally consumed by the planted vegetation. Cut to lawn mowers and landscaping companies hacking futilely away at the vegetation and town planning meetings where people are angrily discussing what to do.

- If you wish, you can end the game with the players deciding the next phase of their plan. Maybe they're going to try and start an environmental movement to save their supernatural marsh. Maybe they're going to try and farm a major charge by turning *all* the farms in the county to zero-waste. Maybe they're planning on using human sacrifices on the knob to keep the runoff contained, and every three years they find the worst polluter in Vermont to sacrifice. If the players already decided their next steps before the final scene, have a cutaway of them planning in the basement of *Troll's Den*, looks of grim determination on their faces.

APPENDIX

TIM BESETTE

Tim is in his early sixties with bright white hair and intense, wrinkly, weather-beaten skin. He wears flannel shirts and bright tan Carhartt's. His clothes are often flecked with mud and dirt from working in the barn and pasture.

Tim doesn't want to kill his son. But he also respects his cabal and feels the process was fair.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Fear Stimulus:** Losing the family farm.
- **Noble Stimulus:** Saving the family farm.
- **Rage Stimulus:** Being disrespected.
- **Agrimancer (Obsession):** 70% (see pp139 of "Play" for further guidance and formulas)
- **Farmer:** 60% Subs for Fitness, Protects: Violence, Provides: Firearms

Shock Meter	Tim Bessette		Abilities
	Hardened	Failed	
Helplessness	2	0	Fitness 50% Dodge 30%
Isolation	5	2	Status 40% Pursuit 40%
Self	3	0	Knowledge 50% Lie 30%
Unnatural	4	0	Notice 45% Secrecy 35%
Violence	5	2	Connect 40% Struggle 40%

SITE & MANNER OF CHARGING	LAKE (FERTILITY)	MARSH (FERTILITY)	LAKE (KNOB)	MARSH (KNOB)
CHARGES NEEDED	100 SIG	30 SIG	N/A	N/A
ACRES CLEANED	1000 (~1 SQ MI)	300 (~.5 SQ MI)	300K+	300 (~.5 SQ MI)
COWS NEEDED	100	30	1000 every 3 days (other animals OK)	1 every 3 days (other animals ok)
PEOPLE NEEDED	100	30	1	N/A

EPILOGUE: MAKING IT PAY OFF

The trickiest part of running "Run Off" is that even though the players need to come up with a fairly short-term solution to solve this problem (to prevent Trevor's death), if their thinking caps are on, they'll realize they need to come up with a long term solution that falls outside the scope of the game. Even most of the "short term" solutions solve the problem for orders of years rather than days.

I don't recommend zooming too far into the future, though. The sense of uncertainty about the long- term consequences of the players actions is part of what makes the game "work" as an Unknown Armies one-shot, similar to famous 2e one-shots like *Jailbreak* or *Bill In 3 Parts*. Rather, cut to the immediate actions the characters must take to solve the problem, if they don't make sense to role-play out, and then cut to a closing scene of the players together.

HOW TO KILL A COW

Before slaughter, cows are shot above (not between) the eyes or the back of the head just above the neck. Then the animal's neck is cut at the jugular in order to drain the blood. It bears mentioning that this game, or any game that includes agrimancers as protags, is not a great pick for people sensitive to animal welfare.

- If the characters' solution involves the sacrifice of people or animals and they aren't doing the sacrificing, cut to a shot of one of the agrimancer farmers, sleeves rolled up and his jeans worn, wearing mud boots. A row of agrimancers is standing behind him, one of them holding a gun. The agrimancers look on intently as he pulls out a knife and grimly steps towards the [first of the] tied-up sacrifice[s]. Be thoughtful about depicting this if it's a human. Cut to black before anything is seen. Watching an animal die on screen is maybe more than you need to do, watching a human die this way on screen is A. Lot.
- If the players use *Fertility* to make some part of the marsh or country club soak up more run-off, after the sacrifice has been made, the plants begin growing almost supernaturally fast, tiny seedling trees turning into 1-year-old plants,

Tim's goal is not to kill the players, and it's certainly not to kill Trevor, who

THE KNOB

The knob is a powerful artifact located near Jo's house. It is based on pp88 of Play, though its powers function slightly differently. See the Appendix for details. The players can also use the knob to prevent Trevor's death—any outcome that prevents the farmers having to deal with agricultural runoff on their own dime is acceptable to them.

must be alive for the major charge to go through. His priority should absolutely be to capture Trevor and get his son to his car unscathed. Use the gridiron for any grappling or pursuit challenges if necessary (pp.69, Play). If the players manage to make enough of a dent in Tim's wound threshold that he's in serious danger, he should run away.

Fights to the death are never a good idea in *Unknown Armies*, but if your players decide they are today and kill Tim, this won't save Trevor. The farmers will use the knob instead—a much riskier and more dangerous way to get what they want, but one that will absolutely work. (It will also work for the players if they decide to use it. More details on the knob can be found on pp25.) Remember to make the players make *violence rank 4* checks if they kill Tim. Trevor should make a *self rank 10*—yes, the absolute highest *self* check—if he kills his father or participates in killing Tim, as he is deliberately killing someone he loves. If he merely watches while the other players kill Tim, it's a *rank 9 helplessness check*. Since he is watching the *other players* do it, you *should strongly* encourage his failed stress check to involve the players regardless of which reaction he chooses—for example, if he chooses flight, he should run away from the other player characters; if he chooses fight, he should fight them and not his father or his father's corpse.

Needless to say, it's best to discourage players from killing Tim. *Unknown Armies* is a game that's pretty grounded in its depiction of violence, even compared to other urban fantasy and horror games, and you should impress on the players that killing people in this game has the kind of consequences it has in real life.

The players can also try to convince Tim that there must be another way. Tim doesn't really want to sacrifice his son, and if the players ask if there's any other way, Tim may offer the following possibilities:

- Tim has heard a rumor that one of his cabal knows of an artifact that, if they sacrifice a life on it, could cure the cyanobacteria in the bay—at least temporarily. Tim thinks either an animal or a human would work, but it will be less powerful with an animal and cover less area. They would have to find it and put it at the mouth of the bay.
- If the city council could be convinced not to pass the law requiring the farmers to deal with their runoff, this would buy them time to figure out something else. If the players ask if the farmers have any other plans or ideas for dealing with the runoff if the law doesn't pass, Tim should sincerely answer that they don't. The players could try to get the city council to pass a version of the law that helps compensate the farmers for dealing with

their industrial waste, but this won't be easy in an impoverished town with a small budget. (If this was a long campaign, that would be a great objective, though.) If the players suggest using blackmail, Tim doesn't know of any blackmail material or if blackmail would work—but this is absolutely a potential avenue for the players to pursue.

- Land Breakers have the ability to make the land more fertile, but only for a harvest, and only an acre. There might be a way to supercharge it, but Tim can't think of one without bankrupting himself by killing all his cows or killing Trevor. (If the players ask if another Farmer's child could sub in, Tim replies yes—but their own father must kill them. The agrimancer has to kill *their own* son for the magick to work.)

To stop Tim from trying to kidnap Trevor or enlist Tim's help, the players must present a *credible* pathway to getting rid of the farmer's problem. If they cannot but insist they will find another way, Tim will grant them 24 hours before he comes to collect Trevor again with the help of his cabal. The players absolutely cannot win a head-on fight with an entire agrimancer cabal, and Tim should make this clear.

From here or from scene 1, the players should have some rough ideas of how to proceed. Here are some places they might go, and what could happen.

with the right incentive... or threat.

3. Trevor could use his "Fertility" formula to clean Lake Petonbowk. It will have to be juiced up considerably from its 1 minor charge version—if it didn't, why would the farmers not do it themselves? As-is, "Fertility" will only clean 1 acre of the lake and only until the next storm. Here are some ways it could be juiced up:
 - a. Trevor could burn significant charges instead of minors. For every significant charge thus burned, 10 acres of lake will remain clean for 3 years. (See: **A TABLE OF SACRIFICE TO CLEAN THE LAKE** on p19 for more details.)
 - b. Although the obvious solution is to use "Fertility" on the Lake itself, the players could also use it on the country club, the suburbs, what's left of the marshlands that feed into Lake Petonbowk, or even a rival farm; anywhere the water winds toward the lake.
 - c. Using Fertility *this way* will make whatever grasses have been planted there go crazy, which will help absorb the runoff from the farms. If the players really want to throw a wrench in the works, they could plant a bunch of marsh plants or trees and turn the whole area into a runoff garden.
 - d. They'd need to use significant charges to really make this effective, at a rate of 1 significant charge per 10 acres. . (See: **A TABLE OF SACRIFICE TO CLEAN THE LAKE** for more details.)
 - e. They'd also need to find a way to keep the people living there from just ripping it all up right away. **But per charge, this is much more effective than using charges on the lake itself.** Turning 10 acres of shortly cropped grass into a prairie or edge forest will keep absorbing phosphorus, in much larger quantities, as long as the plants are maintained well enough to continue doing their job, even if they do so less effectively after their first "harvest."
4. The players could use the knob on the lake basin--or anywhere the *Fertility* formula could be used to solve the run off issue. See "The Knob" for details on how to accomplish this.

A TABLE OF SACRIFICE TO CLEAN THE LAKE

How much of Lake Petonbowk can Trevor clean with significant charges? If they kill all of Trevor's cows, that's around 1,000 acres. (His farm has 100 cows.) This is about the size of the town. Lake Petonbowk is based on the real-life Lake Champlain, which is a gigantic lake of 313,600 acres (514 square miles.) But doing this will clean the entire area suffering the immediate consequences of runoff in St. Andrews, and other algal blooms are someone elses' problem.

How many cows does the entire Agrimancer cabal have? There's around half a dozen, and the average size of a dairy herd in Vermont is 100-200 cows—so that's around 1,500 cows. Each farmer would have to sacrifice an average of 10-30 cows to fire off the same level of juju as Trevor's entire herd.

It's not necessary to get this specific, but if helpful, I have included a table of the possible outcomes for the ritual and the amount of blood you'll have to shed for each outcome in order to stop the algal blooms. Enjoy?

and the other members of the country club prefer to deal in the predictable world of reality, through legislation, hard work (actually money) and explaining to the people of our town why regulating the farmer's activities is so essential."

7: AMBER AND STARSHINE BOOKSTORE

If the players are floundering around too long or having trouble picking up a lead, you can always suggest Alexis hit up their friend Amber, who works at the nearby New Age store "Starshine Bookstore" and is into chaos magic. Amber also has a bit of a read on the occult underground in larger Queen City, such as it is, and can answer basic questions or serve as a source of ideas.

Amber is 20 years old and dresses like a romantic goth or hippie goth, with long dark hair and lots of eye makeup, and a lot of jewelry. She has kind of an always-calm aura (she probably smokes a lot of weed which doesn't hurt, but she's never a menacing presence even stone cold sober) and Starshine Bookstore sells a variety of New Age and Modern Magic materials, most of them the standard sort of thing you'd find in a store of this nature—plus tarot cards, incense, batik tapestries, and, *of course*, crystals.

If your players are floundering badly enough that they need to be helped with possible solutions, Amber could be able to vaguely point to the options listed under "POSSIBLE CONCLUSIONS (pp17)", though you should, as much as possible, have her guide players toward making their own solutions.

FINALE: POSSIBLE CONCLUSIONS

Hopefully, between their character sheets and the helpful NPCs, the players have enough to go on that they can draft a possible solution to the runoff problem. Here are a few possible solutions, but the best *Unknown Armies* games involve the players coming up with their own resolution.

My friend and fellow Unknown Armies GM Collin L once gave the excellent advice, "Generally my attitude is to permit a plan to work for the players if it makes sense using 'UA-logic' and they did their homework." I consider this the ironclad rule of Unknown Armies GMing: the important thing is that the players' plan makes sense according to a peculiar kind of logic—and it has a cost. Everything in UA comes at some kind of cost.

1. The players could decide, improbably, that Trevor's life is worth it for a permanently clean watershed, and allow the agrimancers to sacrifice him. (For what it's worth: this would absolutely work in the manner the agrimancers intend.)
2. It's not likely to work, but the players could try to get another agrimancer farmer to volunteer their son as sacrifice instead.
 - a. See the [appendix](#) (pp19) for quick stats and character concepts for the various farmers.
 - b. Note that some of the farmers probably have sons who up and moved to the city; this is one reason Trevor was a tempting target. However, some farmers may harbor resentment toward children who "went city" and envy that Tim's son stayed behind.
 - c. Some farmers don't have sons or a horse in this race and might switch sides

WHAT IF THE REAL RUN OFF... WAS US

Sigh. Did your players decide to beat town? Please tell me they didn't. They did, didn't they? That's why you're here. Here's what to do if they decide to beat town.

- **It might not be a big deal.** If the characters are only beating town to buy a little time (say a day or two), that's honestly fine. So first, ask them—"How long are you *planning to hide?*" The problem isn't going anywhere, and the same things chasing them around the city will chase them *outside* the city. If they just want a hotel so Trevor can't be found as easily, there's a couple hotels in the city, though the small-town rumor mill might start churning about why Deb is in a hotel room with an almost-minor after a couple of days. If they're just hiding out a day or two, just time skip to when they're ready to deal with this.
- **Remind them of their obsessions, passions, and relationships.** Having a good startup phase helps a lot, but... Deb has a wife, Kim, in town. Does Deb let her know? Her obsession is her *game store*, which cannot go on an impromptu road trip. Trevor is an agrimancer, which means his obsession is *his farm* and his Noble Passion is *nurturing his community*.
- **If they insist those things don't matter, make them take stress checks.** I hope your players like self checks because they're about to get a lot of them. For deliberately abandoning her wife and her game store, Deb takes a rank 8 self check. (It's only a rank 7 if she decides to take Kim with her. Remember to make Deb roll her relationship to see if Kim agrees, per rules on pp37 of *Play*.) For abandoning his noble passion and his adept school, Trevor gets a rank 10 self check. Betraying your passions *sucks* in Unknown Armies. Alexis and Jo get off relatively easy since they have less tying them to town, but they still get rank 5 isolation checks for leaving everything and everyone they know except for these three people.
- **Remember, people are looking for your PCs.** Failed stress checks may give you a golden chance for a servitor to see them and the farmers to hunt them down, or for the cops to check in on Alexis (and her parents will call if she's gone more than 24 hours—see 5: THE COPS AND CITY COUNCIL.) The farmers also have many, many other formulas that are extremely good for finding people or making them regret they didn't face their fears, like making all food taste rancid or striking them with lightning after a week (feel free to time skip if necessary). See [page 138 of "Play."](#) Oh--also, Agrimancers can use *Toil* to get around having to sleep, so they can also do all that stuff without having to rest.
- **Ordering Thai food at an Italian restaurant.** Finally, sometimes running away is a sign that your players just fundamentally don't care about the game's central conflict. If you want Thai food, don't go to an Italian restaurant. Ask them if they actually want to play this game.

3: TREVOR'S HOUSE

If the players go to Trevor's house to confront Tim and the farmers immediately after Trevor's arrival, Tim and the farmers are not there. The house is almost eerily quiet except for gentle mooing from the barn. As the players drive up to Trevor's old colonial, their headlights hit several roughly man-shaped piles of dirt, whose rough-hewn silhouettes cast enormous shadows against the white colonial. These are the servitors of the agrimancer cabal, and as soon as they can viably said to have spotted Trevor, they will begin moving away from the house and off in the four cardinal directions to find a member of the agrimancer cabal to report to. All PCs (except for Trevor, who will recognize what the servitors are) make an *unnatural rank 3 check*.

NOTES ON ANNE

Anne is not magic and she doesn't understand how Trevor or Tim's magic works— or how any magic works, for that matter. But she does know it exists and she has seen both her husband and son use it.

If the players make subtext text and ask if they think Trevor was targeted because of his ethnicity, see Anne's character description for more in-depth notes on her experiences with that.

If the players don't begin attacking the servitors to dispel them, the players hear the overpowering *bang* of shotgun fire and see that a gun has been fired out of a window, dispelling one of the servitors. This is Trevor's mother, Anne, though the players don't necessarily know this. (If Trevor's player asks if it could be his family, remind Trevor that he lives with his mother and father.) There are four servitors in total, and the GM should call for notice checks to see if the players succeed in noticing all of them. Anne should also complete a notice check at a -10% shift (since she is viewing the servitors from out a window at night.) If the players do not kill all of them, one of the Servitors will return to an agrimancer and report that Trevor has returned to his farm. Servitors aren't especially fast, so the players will have an hour or two to do whatever it is they want to accomplish before two agrimancers show up and attempt to capture Trevor at his home.

If the players go inside the house or hang around outside in the front yard, Anne, Trevor's mother, will meet up with them and warn them that Tim's friends placed the servitors there to look for Trevor in case he returned, and she will advise them to leave as quickly as possible. If the players ask Anne for help or information, she will help to the best of her ability.

Anne is in her early sixties, with long, bright silver hair. She dresses in practical workwear. Her day job is in the wastewater treatment facility, and she's knowledgeable in the causes of the blooms. She can't tell the players how to stop the blooms supernaturally, but she can advise them on how to stop them the boring 'ol natural way:

- The source of the blooms is, in fact, the manure and nitrous/fertilizer runoff from farms and lawns.
- The problem is exacerbated by the fact that much of the natural streambeds,

6: THE GOLF COURSE

BLACKMAILING KAREN

You know what would get Karen to roll back the requirements for farmers? Blackmail. For ideas on blackmail material, see the appendix under "Karen Reynolds."

Some players may immediately head to what feels like a likely source of supernatural mischief; the country club and its attached golf course. The country club is around 150 acres, mostly golf course, with a 90s McMansion-style club house and attached restaurant and parking lot. There is a stream that winds its way through the golf course that eventually empties into the swamp adjacent to St. Andrew's bay.

The country club and the golf course don't contain any supernatural mischief, however, even if the players investigate it—Karen and the wealthy suburbanites who frequent the country club don't need supernatural power to solve their problems. They have plenty of regular power, in the form of the city council and their fungible assets, to accomplish their goals. That said, having regular power means they can get up to regular mischief: there are useful hints here for how to resolve the ongoing lake issue—and most of them have to do with Karen. If the players investigate the country club, you should feel free to have Karen show up, taking a meal at the restaurant or golfing and flirting gratuitously with any waiters, caddies, or other young, attractive staff if she doesn't notice or see Alexis. (Feel free to have Alexis roll *SECRECY* if needed.) The players can hit these service staff up for blackmail material per the [Appendix entry on Karen](#) (pp21).

If the players snoop in the back office and sneak their way past any Country Club admin staff, they will also find an environmental report explaining that the lack of stormwater mitigation measures at the Country Club and the surrounding Suburbs is exacerbating the algal blooms. This report isn't, by itself, enough to get the Council to reverse course. Karen and the other councilors are already aware that they're contributing to the algal blooms, they just want to make it someone else's problem. The City Council is dependent on a donor list that consists of members of the country club and St. Andrews suburbia—when they're not, in Karen Reynolds case, actively members themselves. If the players don't come to this conclusion on their own, a successful *Punk* identity roll from Alexis will clue the players into the fact that just having proof that the country club and the suburbs are partially responsible is not enough. They need an additional form of pressure.

A conversation with Karen or trying to follow up with the City Council on the runoff problems caused by the Country Club can open up the "[Let's Make a Deal](#) (pp15)" conversation under "[5: THE COPS AND CITY COUNCIL](#) (pp13)." "

If the players just can't seem to drop the idea that the country club *must* be trucking in the supernatural, feel free to have Karen mention that she knows the farmers use some kind of weird occult magick, "though even if it worked, I

LET'S MAKE A DEAL

Karen Reynolds is a woman in her early sixties with salt and pepper hair. It's late at night, so she's dressed down, wearing jeans and a t-shirt with a cardigan. She sits down with the players and addresses Trevor. She is confident, proper, and stubborn as hell, all qualities that have served her well as a city councilor who represents the wealthy suburbs of St. Andrews.

Karen Reynolds immediately offers to help make this problem go away; with testimony from Trevor and his help finding Tim, she will arrest Tim and get the deed for the farm wrested from him as well as the deeds from his farmer's cabal. How you proceed should depend on how Trevor reacts. *Theoretically*, Trevor's status as an agrimancer and a kid who wants to take over the farm should mean he would approach a deal like this very cautiously, but it's hard to predict how invested the player will become in their character's backstory! That said, if Trevor does anything to betray his dad to the cops or city council, he should make a *rank 4 self check*. **If Trevor does anything to jeopardize his farm, he should make a rank 7 self check.**

- If Trevor does not mention being concerned about the eventual fate of his farm (who will be turned over to?) Alexis should make a notice roll with a +10% shift. She should automatically succeed in being incredulous of her suddenly chummy parents, but on a success, she additionally knows that her mother would probably rather have that land developed than stay in the hands of a farmer.
- If Trevor says he wants to continue to run the farm, but doesn't care what happens to his dad or any of the other farmers, Karen offers him the best lawyer that money can buy to make sure the deed stays in his name, and to leave him out of any attempts to use eminent domain or asset forfeiture to seize the cabal's farms. For what it's worth—this offer is sincere, and Karen really would help Trevor keep the farm in his name.
- If Trevor tries to convince Karen to help him get the city council to roll back the requirements for the farmers, or to pay for the requirements out of the city's budget (or by levying a tax on the developers or wealthy suburbanites), Karen will not agree to this. Indeed, if Trevor insists on some version of this, she will act as though she is incredulous about Trevor's story about the agrimancers and insist that he is exaggerating or making it up. (She is not really at all credulous, though. Karen is well aware of the farmers' powers.)
- If Jo uses their mesmer powers, this can definitely affect Karen's willingness to go along with the players attempts or plans, but remember that at some point it's worth it to Karen to take the stress check from coercion rather than give up on her Noble Passion, "create the perfect small town."

Karen doesn't force the players into a decision, but if they refuse her deal, the Sheriff's office keeps a close eye on the players and they should see a police cruiser casually follow them on any future encounters, alongside the clay servitors. Unless Alexis is threatened, the Sheriff should not intervene directly with the players. **Although Karen would certainly love an excuse to steal a bunch of land, her primary motivation is just to make the pond scam problem go away without impacting her own (suburban, golf-playing) lifestyle**—she should only intervene if the players' plan somehow involves messing up the land she or the golf course occupy.

swamps and marshes have been drained, both for farmland and for development. Most of the runoff simply washes down culverts and roads, never absorbing into natural vegetation, and the suburban developments and Petonbowk Country Club are making the problem significantly worse.

- If the streambeds could be restored or swamps made whole again by or on the lakefront developments and country club, the farmers' jobs in mitigating runoff would be significantly easier.
- Just having proof that the country club is partially responsible for the runoff issue isn't enough to take the heat off the Farmers; the City Council is dependent on a donor list that consists of many regular members of the country club and St. Andrews suburbia.
- Restoring streambeds and swamps is painstaking, difficult, years-long work, and the players cannot do it through mundane means in time to prevent Trevor's death. I hope your players like learning about stormwater mitigation!

If the players ask Anne to come with them, she refuses, unless her expertise is very directly helpful to them in some way—her absence will attract attention. If the players talk to Anne for very long (Really? They liked the stormwater mitigation stuff?) have them and Anne roll notice checks. If one of the servitors escaped, two agrimancers should show up. If the players got all of them, Tim should appear again, and the scene can proceed more-or-less as Scene 2. In either case, if Anne or any of the players make their notice check, they see another car coming up the driveway and Anne encourages them to escape out back through the corn field.

4: THE CORN MAZE, THE KNOB, AND JO'S HOUSE

The corn maze behind Trevor's house is enchanted per the formula Crop Labyrinth (pp148 of Play.) Because Trevor's father cast the spell, Trevor can easily make his way through the labyrinth and to Jo's house; any other character must either follow Trevor or else make 3 successful knowledge rolls to navigate through it. Each roll (successful or failed) represents 10 minutes. Any farmers (except Tim) pursuing the characters must also make these rolls. Any players who navigate partially or totally to Jo's house on foot for any reason will also encounter the corn maze. If your players make a bee-line for Jo's house at the top of the adventure, it's a good idea to make a point of describing the corn field since it appears on Jo's character sheet and you may want to remind the players the knob exists, since it is one way of solving Trevor's problem. Additionally, you may wish to make the corn maze belong to another farmer and for Jo to live further from Tim Bessette if they go directly to Jo's house without stopping by Trevor's house first.

Regardless, when or if the players come out of the corn maze they appear near Jo's house, adjacent to a strange, eerie-looking stump—the knob. The stump is four feet wide and has four recessed handles, such that one person could lift the knob on each side. It's deeply scored with the marks of axes, and its darkly rust colored. It looks as though it could be the site of sacrifice. Trevor may make a gutter magick roll to recognize the knob as something one of the farmers, Angela and Peter Wright, mentioned once. Or, the players

could ask Amber (Alexis' occult obsessed friend) or Tim. Jo recognizes it as the stump he's seen once before, but he doesn't know what it is or what it does. For more information on how the players could use the knob, see [the knob](#) (pp25) in the appendix.

Inside, Jo's house is cramped but neat, and by far the safest location for Trevor. If Alexis spends the night anywhere but their own house, Karen should roll to see if she notices her child is gone (see "Karen Reynolds" in the [appendix](#) on pp21). Regardless, a servitor will eventually appear to on behalf of Tim and the other agrimancers to try and find Trevor. The PCs should make checks to notice the servitor and warn Trevor, who may wish to try and hide. If Trevor successfully notices and hides from the servitors, they pass by Jo's house without finding Trevor.

MISGENDERING ALEXIS

You'll notice that Alexis' assigned at birth gender is not included in their character description, but the text is explicit that certain antagonists are likely to misgender them. You should limit this to people who are not likely to know Alexis and who are not likely to respect their agency in knowing their gender. Also, it's a good idea to check in with Alexis' player and make sure they're comfortable with this element of the story. Make sure to use safety tools like script change with this game (and any UA game).

How do you proceed as the GM? If Alexis' PC specifies their assigned-at-birth gender, you should use that. Otherwise, roll 1d10, pick evens for one gender and odds for the other. Is it weird and arbitrary to decide how to gender someone in your game based on a random whim and not their agency as a person? Yes. It is. That's sort of the idea.

Finally, I really want to strongly discourage you from choosing how to misgender based on Alexis' players' gender, if they identify with a binary gender. If your impulse is to do this, I think it's better just to excise this part of Alexis' backstory. Lots of people are willing enough to use correct pronouns while finding other ways to de-legitimize their personhood.

If your players engage more deeply than you expect with this part of the story, see pp26 for more notes and guidance.

5: THE COPS AND CITY COUNCIL

Being the sort of game that's generally filled with losers who think they can change the world, my experience is Unknown Armies PCs generally aren't super-fast on the trigger finger with the 'ol 911 service. But, well, Trevor's dad is literally trying to sacrifice his son to clean up a bunch of pond scum along with his farmer friends, and it's not off-the-wall to think "maybe we should call an authority figure."

Additionally, Alexis' parents certainly have no fear of authority figures. If Alexis is out past 1 am or so, their parents might notice they're gone, and

Karen should make a check to this effect (see "Karen Reynolds" in the appendix). At that point, they'll start calling Alexis' cell phone, and by morning, they'd call the town sheriff. Most people make you wait 24 hours before they'll go looking for your kid, but Alexis' mom is on city council and has a pretty strong "talk to your manager" energy. Whether you exercise sending the town sheriff after your players depends on how strong their desire to lollygag through this adventure is—if they're waffling a lot, or don't feel a lot of urgency to deal with this, then pull the trigger.

Here's what happens if the players call the cops, the sheriff shows up, or they go to City Council directly.

The Cops will arrive on the scene and immediately recognize Alexis as the child of Karen Reynolds, a prominent city council member. If they're specifically there to get Alexis, they won't waste any time in trying to do that. If they aren't, you can have them show a little leeway.

The Sheriff, David Daigle, is a plump man in his mid-fifties, balding and bored-looking. He will probably try to calm Trevor down and insist he's over-reacting. But if the players demand this is serious collectively, the Sheriff will take them back to the station and ask them a few questions, namely who the farmers are that are chasing them, why they want to kill Trevor, and if he knows where the farmers are now. The sheriff will wander off and call Karen, who has asked to be kept abreast of any happenings having to do with the farmers and the runoff.

If the players are open about the supernatural elements involved in what's happening to Trevor, the Sheriff doesn't take them very seriously, but does believe that the farmers might believe them, or a less sensationalistic version of the truth. "We've heard all kinds of weird rumors about what the farmers get up to and the City Council has asked the Sheriff's department to keep an eye on them." David will then go and call Karen (who probably wants to know where her kid is, anyway).

At this point, Karen Reynolds shows up at the Sheriff's office. Alexis probably thinks this is to collect her (which isn't entirely false) but Karen is actually here for another purpose.

ALEXIS AND KAREN

Karen (and her father, Brad) misgender Alexis when/if they appear "onscreen" when referring to them in the third person. (See the MISGENDERING ALEXIS sidebar.) If Alexis or another player corrects Karen, Karen will ignore them, which is a rank 2 self check for Alexis. (They should easily pass this, with four hardened notches and a protective identity—but the check alerts the PCs that the experience is upsetting for Alexis.) If the characters attempt to coerce Karen into using the correct pronouns, note that they will most likely receive a +1 bonus since Karen's fear stimulus is *losing her child*. By the by--because of their mesmer power and the number of stimuli in play, Jo can force a rank 5 unnatural check on Karen for misgendering Alexis.